
Business Processes

Study Notes

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Introduction

Learning Objectives

1. Explain what a business process is.
2. Identify common process characteristics.
3. Explain why organizations model processes.

1.1 Business Processes

A **business process** is a collection of related activities that produces a specific outcome. Processes transform inputs into outputs and create value for a customer or another stakeholder.

Definition 1.1 Business Process

A structured collection of activities designed to achieve a particular organizational objective. A process has an identifiable beginning, result, and recipient of that result. For a simple process, the transformation can be summarized as

$$\text{Input} + \text{Activities} \longrightarrow \text{Output}.$$

Key Concept Process Owner

A process owner is accountable for the performance and ongoing improvement of a particular business process. The role crosses organizational boundaries when necessary to ensure the process meets its objectives.

Example Online Order

An online purchase may consist of receiving an order, verifying payment, preparing the package, shipping it, and confirming delivery. These activities work together to produce the outcome: the customer receives the correct order.

Important

A process should have a clearly identifiable input and output. Listing tasks without identifying the result does not fully describe a process.

Note

The people who perform a process do not necessarily own or manage it. Process ownership is an accountability role, not simply a job title.

1.2 A Simple Process View

The following table gives an example of inputs, activities, and outputs.

Stage	Example	Purpose
Input	Customer order	Starts the process
Activities	Validate, pack, ship	Transform the input
Output	Delivered order	Meets the customer's need

1.3 Revision Questions

Q1.1. What is a business process?

Q1.2. What are the main characteristics of a business process?

Q1.3. What is a process owner?

Answer: The person accountable for the performance and improvement of a specific business process.

Exam Q1.4.

Explain why defining a process output is important when deciding whether a collection of activities forms a process.

The definition is given in Definition 1.1; Question 1.1 and Question 1.3 are useful for revision.

Chapter Summary

The main ideas from this chapter are:

- Business processes consist of related activities.
- Processes transform inputs into outputs.
- Every process should have a clear objective and outcome.

Process Architecture

Learning Objectives

1. Define process architecture.
2. Distinguish primary, management, and supporting processes.
3. Explain how a process architecture supports analysis.

2.1 Organizing Processes

A **process architecture** is an organized view of the processes in an enterprise and the relationships between them. It helps people see how work across teams contributes to organizational goals.

Definition 2.1 Process Architecture

A structured overview of an organization's processes and their relationships. It may group processes into primary, management, and supporting categories.

Process type	Main purpose	Example
Primary	Deliver value to customers	Fulfil a customer order
Management	Direct and monitor the organization	Set business goals
Supporting	Enable other processes	Maintain information systems

Key Concept End-to-end perspective

A process architecture makes dependencies visible across departments. Analyze how the complete process delivers an outcome rather than optimizing each team in isolation.

2.2 Representing a Workflow

Programming and technical subjects can use the same template. The code block below illustrates an order validation step.

```
1 public class Order
2 {
3     public int Id { get; set; }
4
5     public bool IsValid()
6     {
7         return Id > 0;
8     }
9 }
```

Other supported code languages include JavaScript, TypeScript, Python, SQL, HTML, CSS, and Bash. Use the spelling shown in the language name.

2.3 Revision Questions

Q2.1. What is process architecture?

Q2.2. What distinguishes a primary process from a supporting process?

Answer: A primary process delivers value directly to customers; a supporting process supplies capabilities or resources that enable other processes.

Exam Q2.3.

Explain how a process architecture can reveal opportunities for improvement.

Answer: It makes relationships and handoffs visible, helping identify duplication, bottlenecks, unclear responsibilities, and gaps between processes.

See Definition 2.1 and Question 2.2 when reviewing the process categories.

Important

A process category describes the role a process plays in the organization; it does not indicate that one category is inherently more important than another.

Chapter Summary

- Process architecture organizes processes and shows their connections.
- Primary processes deliver customer value.
- Management and supporting processes enable effective delivery.